



Background

- Psychedelic and entactogenic therapies are moving toward clinical use faster than the field has agreed on the psychotherapy that should accompany them.
- A central feature of psychedelic experience is the noetic quality - a *metacognitive feeling of epistemic gain*: a felt sense of understanding that does not reliably track truth.¹
- The clinical question is therefore epistemic: What should be done with an insight that feels true?

Core Argument

1

Mechanism and hazard are the same event.

The opening that lets rigid high-level priors be revised is the same opening that increases suggestibility. Openness and suggestibility are one effect seen from two sides.^{2,3}

2

Conviction cannot simply be removed.

The felt certainty is bound up with the therapeutic experience, not merely standing beside it. Reducing it risks weakening the therapeutic action along with the risk.⁴

3

The task is to metabolise conviction.

Let the experience reorganise the person - keeping its force and meaning - while its content is tested over time.
Neither suppression nor credulity.
We argue that this technology already exists in DBT.

Conceptual Frame

Ordinarily

Under psychedelics

From felt insight to possible outcomes

REBUS*
psychedelics reduce the precision of entrenched high-level priors.²

FIBUS**
the "aha!" recruits available content to explain the signal.⁵

Therapeutic opportunity

- Openness
- Learning
- Positive change

Epistemic risk

- False beliefs
- Maladaptive choices
- Harm

*There is a single dial.
Turning it down to reduce the risk turns down the cure as well.*

* REBUS - Relaxed Beliefs Under Psychedelics

** FIBUS - False Insights and Beliefs Under Psychedelics

Dialectical Behaviour Therapy (DBT)

- A structured, manualised evidence-based psychotherapy built around a central dialectic of acceptance and change.^{6,7}
- Integrates acceptance-based and change-oriented strategies to enhance emotion regulation, reduce maladaptive behaviours and improve functioning.⁸

Acceptance

Validate the experience and accept it as it is

Dialectic

Accept what is, while working to change what can change

Change

Build skills and actively change what is not working

Core components

Mindfulness

Distress tolerance

Emotion regulation

Interpersonal effectiveness

PA-DBT (psychedelic-assisted DBT) Sequence

DBT brackets the session: intention is set before, and evidence is tested after.

Preparation
(control online)
Build skills and safety

- Chain analysis of the problem
- Intention from evidence, not theory
- Commitment to test later

Dosing session
monitoring only
(control offline)

- Observe and describe
- Non-judgemental stance
- Let the experience unfold; No truth-testing

Integration
(control back online)

- Check the facts
- Pros and cons before acting
- Translate to daily life

Metacognition has two functions:
monitoring - awareness of what is happening in one's cognitive system, and control - effortful mental actions that regulate cognitive processes.

DBT Skills Across the PA-DBT Sequence

DBT Skill	What it is (plainly)	Epistemic operation	Implication in PA-DBT	Phase / Mode
Observe + Describe	Notice and name inner events without acting or interpreting	Catch felt certainty and separate signal from content	Lets the felt certainty be registered without being fused to a belief	Dosing - Monitoring
Non-judgemental stance	Notice without rating good/bad or true/false	Notice "this feels true" without ruling it true	Keeps the amplified "aha!" from silently becoming fact	Dosing - Monitoring
STOP	Pause, step back, observe, then proceed mindfully	Create a pause between conviction and action	Prevents irreversible action before testing	Session -> integration - Bridge
Pros and cons	Weigh short- and long-term costs and benefits of acting on an urge	Test a conviction's practical implications before enactment	Applied before high-stakes action: ending a relationship, leaving a job, confronting a parent	Integration - Bridge
Distress tolerance + Radical acceptance	Allow painful uncertainty without fighting or escaping it	Hold the experience without forcing premature closure	Prevents the experience from being suppressed or prematurely resolved before it can be tested	Throughout - Support
Wise mind	Integrate emotional experience and reason from a mindful stance	Create a reflective stance from which conviction can be examined	Pair with Check the facts before drawing conclusions	Integration - Bridge
Check the facts	A stepwise test of whether an emotion fits the facts that prompted it	Test whether an appraisal is warranted	Tests present-tense appraisals and action-urges against current evidence, not historical truth	Integration - Control
Behavioural chain analysis	A step-by-step reconstruction of the sequence leading to a behaviour	Reconstruct the context and causal sequence surrounding a behaviour or conviction	Brackets the session - intention built from evidence before, conviction tested against it after	Preparation + integration - Control
Diary card - Behavioural activation	Track daily states, meaning, actions and outcomes	Test conviction against new real-world evidence	Find where meaning lives and test convictions in daily life	Integration + beyond - Control
DEAR MAN - GIVE - FAST	Interpersonal effectiveness skills for asking, relating and maintaining self-respect	Preserve uncertainty in interpersonal communication inside a relationship	When metabolising needs a real conversation, held without presuming the conviction true	After testing - Generalisation

Endpoint: A life worth living - translate what survives testing into values-aligned patterns of living.

One Discipline, Three Scales

Patient

Insight emerges -> integration tests it (with skills and structure)

Clinician

Personal conviction -> supervision / disclosure tests it

Field

Collective enthusiasm -> peer review / replication tests it

Conclusion

- Psychedelic therapy does not only generate insight - it generates the problem of what to do with insight.
- Cure and risk arise from the same altered state; safety cannot come from making the experience smaller.
- DBT supplies a staged, evidence-based way to metabolise conviction across the whole arc of care.
- The framework is conceptual - and empirically testable.

Take Home Message

Do not suppress the insight.

Do not simply believe it.

Hold it lightly enough to test it.

To metabolise an insight is neither to doubt it into nothing nor to swallow it whole.
It is to honour it enough to discover whether it is true.

If this sparked something...

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References

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